



In Bengal, the Left is trapped in the daze of a double somersault. It must be, in its secret moments, rueing its success at having kept the BJP out of Bengal. It has, thereby, eliminated any Muslim fear at the consequences of a Left defeat. The CPI(M) banyan was semi-uprooted for only one reason, a dramatic swing in the Bengali Muslim vote. The Census says that 28 per cent of Bengal is Muslim; this percentage rises on polling day since Muslims poll in higher numbers. In 2009 Bengal's Muslims decided to vote for something more than life-security. They voted for the promise of bread.

The Marxist formula for the Muslim vote was no different from the Congress prescription: protection from riots, after which they could go fend for themselves. Bengali Muslims have established a new line. This "soft secularism" of marginal existence is not enough. The Left Front never recovered from the gut-wrenching finding of the Sachar Committee Report that Muslim representation in state jobs was much higher in Narendra Modi's Gujarat than in Buddhadeb Bhattacharya's Bengal. But the switch to Mamata Banerjee was not automatic, indicating again a new sophistication in thinking. She had to work for her gains. The dissolution of her ties with the NDA was less important than the manner in which she had empowered Muslims by giving them substantive positions after her victory in the panchayat polls.

In Assam, under the leadership of Badruddin Ajmal, Muslims have taken a further stride. They are developing an independent political party, in alliance with other sections who feel marginalised. This is still a work in progress, and has not translated into the number of seats that their numbers could command. But each election shows a higher return on political investment. In any case, Muslims are getting disenchanted with a system in which they might be the decisive vote in creating a majority in Parliament, but their numbers in the Lok Sabha decline with every general election. The present Lok Sabha has the lowest number of Muslims since 1952.

Bengal's Muslims are in the vanguard of change because the Bengali Muslim vote is almost totally subaltern. There is no elite to either lead or mislead the poor. This is the exact opposite of the situation in Uttar Pradesh, where a self-styled elite, bolstered by comparative affluence or social prominence, has be-

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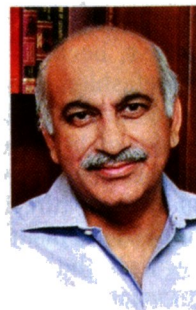
BENGAL'S MUSLIMS DECIDED TO VOTE FOR SOMETHING MORE THAN LIFE-SECURITY. THEY VOTED FOR THE PROMISE OF BREAD.

come a class of middlemen which brokers deal with authority, and rips off the best benefits for itself in the name of the community.

Nitish Kumar, in a brilliant manoeuvre, has understood the mechanics of this lever, and is separating the Muslim elite from the majority of the community. This will change the electoral politics of Bihar over the next decade, if he can sustain the initiative. His real test will come in the Assembly elections of 2010. If he wins, he will reduce the traditional elite to a non-entity and create a new leadership. If he loses, politics will go back to the routine that has dominated the last six decades.

Has the Left, a serious claimant for Muslim support since its credentials remain strong despite its mistakes, understood why it was rejected in Bengal? (Kerala is a different story; in a sense, there are no minorities in Kerala since every community is a minority.) News from the Politburo does not indicate that the Left has learnt very much. But it is possible that the real churning is going on in drawing rooms rather than in the party office.

Fear of the future is at last being edged out by anger at the present. The change is long overdue. It has come because the poor among the Muslims have finally discovered the value of assertion. It used to be said that what Bengal thinks today, India thinks tomorrow—or, if you want a less happy metaphor, when Bengal sneezes, India catches a cold. The Bengali Muslim has sneezed. ■



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